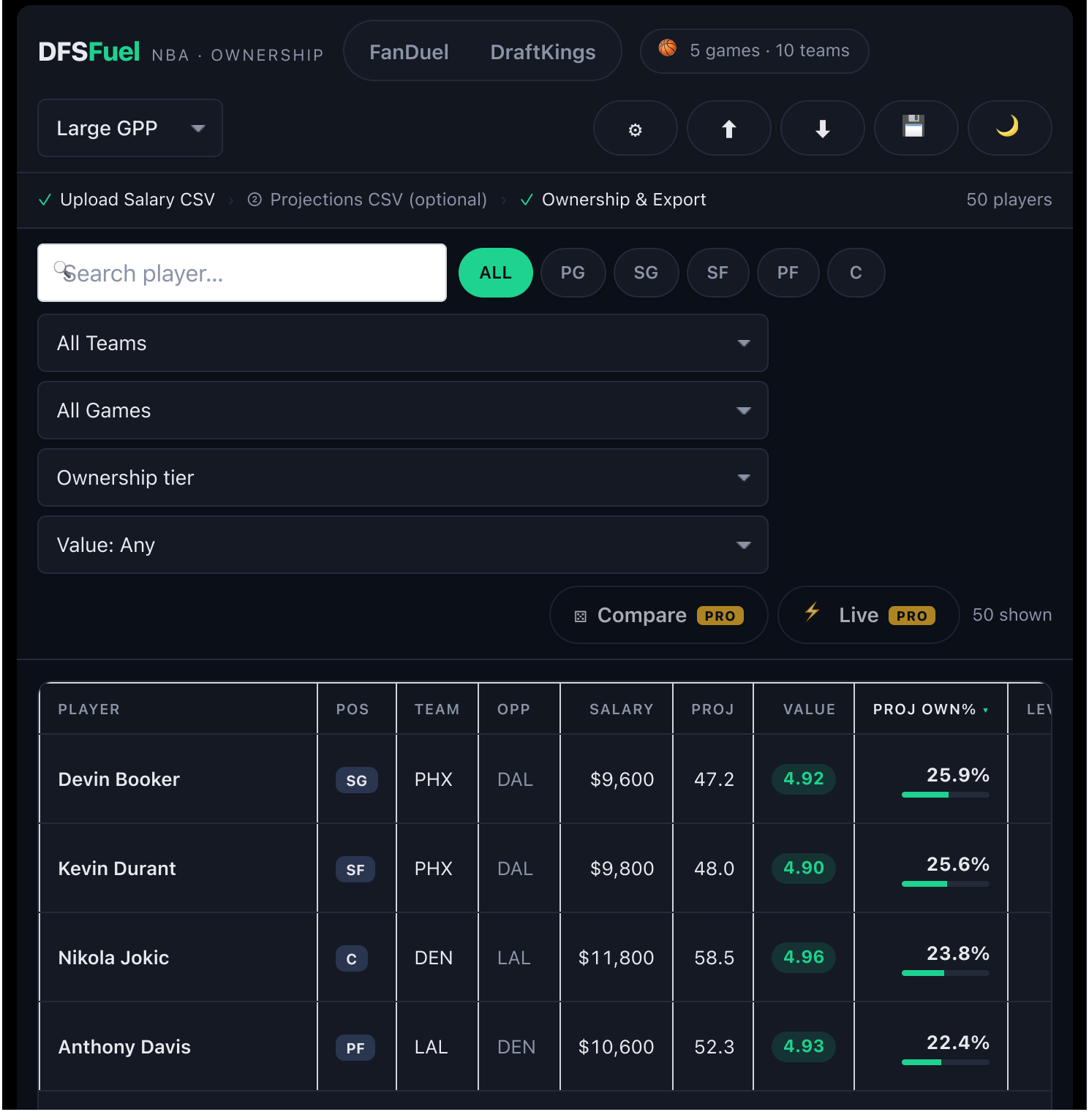
DAILYFANTASYPRO

NBA DFS Ownership Projections

Track live NBA DFS ownership projections for DraftKings and FanDuel. Spot chalk, find leverage, build sharper lineups.

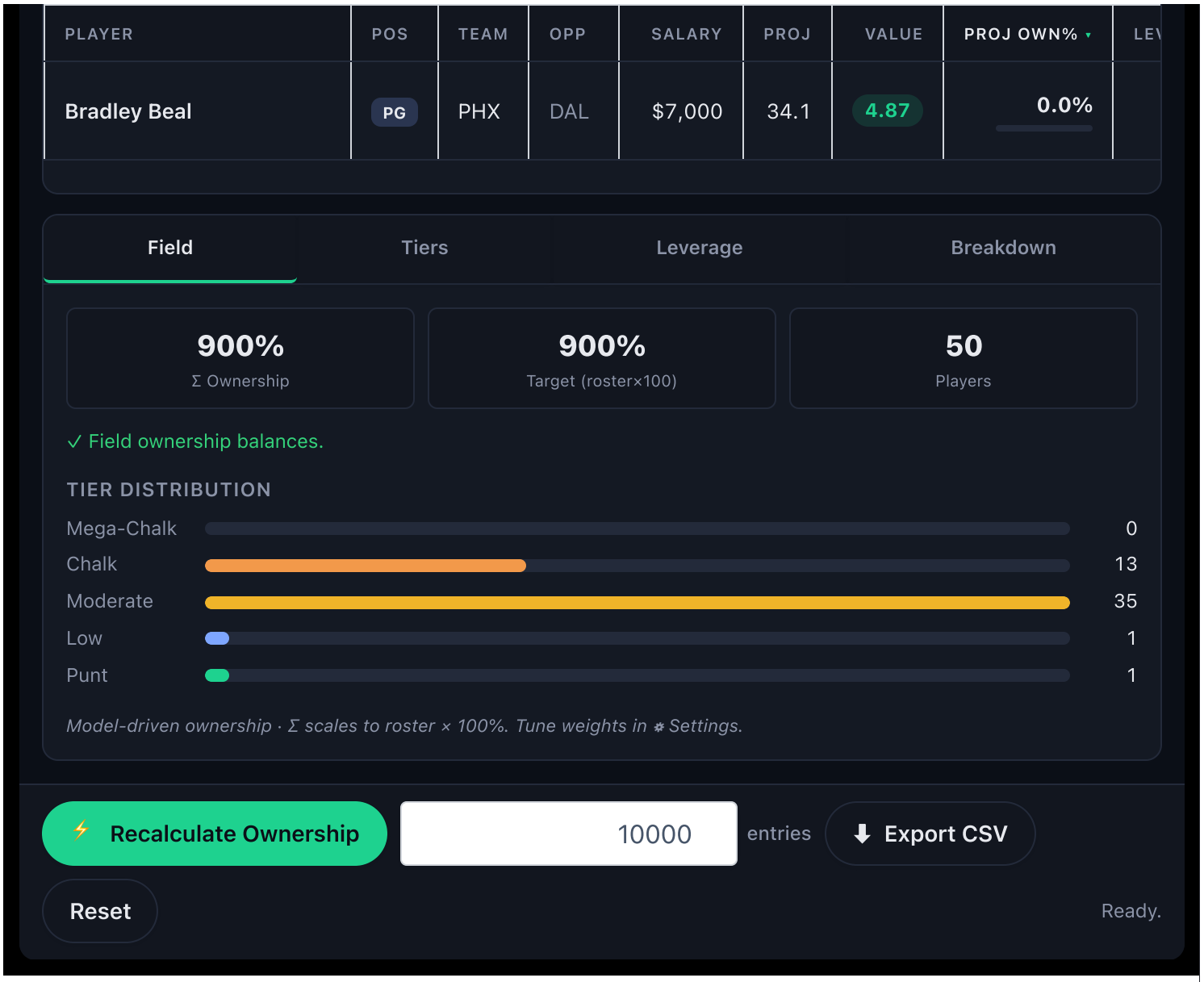


PLAYER	POS	TEAM	OPP	SALARY	PROJ	VALUE	PROJ OWN%	LEV
Devin Booker	SG	PHX	DAL	$9,600	47.2	4.92	25.9%	
Kevin Durant	SF	PHX	DAL	$9,800	48.0	4.90	25.6%	
Nikola Jokic	C	DEN	LAL	$11,800	58.5	4.96	23.8%	
Anthony Davis	PF	LAL	DEN	$10,600	52.3	4.93	22.4%	

PLAYER	POS	TEAM	OPP	SALARY	PROJ	VALUE	PROJ OWN%	LEV
Giannis Antetokounmpo	PF	MIL	PHI	$11,200	55.5	4.96	22.3%	
Jamal Murray	PG	DEN	LAL	$7,600	38.2	5.03	22.0%	
LeBron James	SF	LAL	DEN	$10,200	50.1	4.91	21.8%	
Jusuf Nurkic	C	PHX	DAL	$5,400	26.5	4.91	21.5%	
Joel Embiid	C	PHI	MIL	$11,000	54.0	4.91	21.3%	
Luka Doncic	PG	DAL	PHX	$11,500	57.0	4.96	20.9%	
Jayson Tatum	PF	BOS	MIA	$10,100	49.5	4.90	20.9%	
Bam Adebayo	C	MIA	BOS	$8,200	40.5	4.94	20.3%	
Damian Lillard	PG	MIL	PHI	$9,000	44.2	4.91	20.0%	
Jaylen Brown	SG	BOS	MIA	$8,400	41.2	4.90	19.9%	
Tyrese Maxey	PG	PHI	MIL	$8,800	43.2	4.91	19.9%	
Jimmy Butler	SF	MIA	BOS	$8,800	43.0	4.89	19.9%	
Domantas Sabonis	C	SAC	GSW	$9,600	47.5	4.95	19.7%	
Kristaps Porzingis	C	BOS	MIA	$7,200	35.5	4.93	19.6%	
Austin Reaves	SG	LAL	DEN	$6,000	29.5	4.92	19.1%	

PLAYER	POS	TEAM	OPP	SALARY	PROJ	VALUE	PROJ OWN%	LEV
Jrue Holiday	PG	BOS	MIA	$5,600	27.8	4.96	19.1%	
Tyler Herro	SG	MIA	BOS	$6,800	33.4	4.91	19.1%	
Aaron Gordon	PF	DEN	LAL	$5,800	28.4	4.90	18.7%	
De'Aaron Fox	PG	SAC	GSW	$9,200	45.1	4.90	18.7%	
Stephen Curry	PG	GSW	SAC	$9,400	46.0	4.89	18.7%	
D'Angelo Russell	PG	LAL	DEN	$6,600	32.0	4.85	18.5%	
Michael Porter Jr.	SF	DEN	LAL	$6,200	30.1	4.85	18.3%	
Derrick White	PG	BOS	MIA	$6,400	31.2	4.88	18.3%	
Kyrie Irving	SG	DAL	PHX	$8,600	42.1	4.90	18.2%	
Khris Middleton	SF	MIL	PHI	$6,600	32.1	4.86	17.9%	
Kentavious Caldwell-Pope	SG	DEN	LAL	$4,200	20.5	4.88	17.6%	
Terry Rozier	PG	MIA	BOS	$6,000	29.0	4.83	17.5%	
Bobby Portis	PF	MIL	PHI	$4,800	23.5	4.90	17.4%	
Tobias Harris	SF	PHI	MIL	$5,600	27.0	4.82	16.8%	
Draymond Green	PF	GSW	SAC	$5,400	26.5	4.91	16.7%	

PLAYER	POS	TEAM	OPP	SALARY	PROJ	VALUE	PROJ OWN% ▾	LEV
Daniel Gafford	C	DAL	PHX	$5,200	25.5	4.90	16.5%	
Brook Lopez	C	MIL	PHI	$5,200	25.0	4.81	16.4%	
Malik Monk	SG	SAC	GSW	$5,000	24.5	4.90	16.4%	
Klay Thompson	SG	GSW	SAC	$5,800	28.2	4.86	16.3%	
Grayson Allen	SG	PHX	DAL	$4,600	21.5	4.67	16.2%	
Jonathan Kuminga	PF	GSW	SAC	$5,600	27.2	4.86	16.1%	
P.J. Washington	PF	DAL	PHX	$5,000	24.2	4.84	15.6%	
Keegan Murray	SF	SAC	GSW	$5,400	26.0	4.81	15.5%	
Andrew Wiggins	SF	GSW	SAC	$5,000	24.1	4.82	15.4%	
Kelly Oubre Jr.	SG	PHI	MIL	$4,800	22.5	4.69	14.7%	
Rui Hachimura	PF	LAL	DEN	$4,800	22.1	4.60	14.4%	
Harrison Barnes	PF	SAC	GSW	$4,200	19.8	4.71	13.8%	
Dereck Lively II	C	DAL	PHX	$4,600	21.0	4.57	12.4%	
Duncan Robinson	SF	MIA	BOS	$4,400	19.5	4.43	12.1%	
Nicolas Batum	SF	PHI	MIL	$3,800	16.0	4.21	9.8%	



NBA DFS Ownership Projections: How to Read the Field and Win in 2026

Last Updated: July 2026

You've got a lineup you love. Great salary spread, sharp value plays, a stud in the middle. Then you check the ownership and realize half the field built the exact same thing. That sinking feeling? That's what NBA DFS ownership projections are built to prevent.

NBA DFS ownership projections estimate the percentage of contest lineups that will roster each player. Get that read right and you know exactly where the crowd is heading, which lets you follow it in cash games and cut against it in tournaments. This guide covers how these numbers are made, how to actually use them, and where the field's math trips people up.

At DailyFantasyPro, we build ownership data straight into the optimizer so you're not toggling between five tabs 20 minutes before lock. Here's everything that number is telling you.

Table of Contents

- What NBA DFS Ownership Projections Actually Mean
- How Ownership Projections Are Calculated
- Why DraftKings and FanDuel Ownership Never Match
- Using Ownership in Cash Games vs Tournaments
- Leverage: The Real Reason Ownership Matters
- Chalk, Chalk Traps, and When to Eat the Chalk
- The Late-Swap Window Where Ownership Shifts
- The Lineup Duplication Math People Get Wrong
- How Accurate Are These Projections, Really?
- Frequently Asked Questions

What NBA DFS Ownership Projections Actually Mean

An ownership projection is the expected share of lineups that will include a given player. If Nikola Jokić projects at 40% ownership, roughly 4 in 10 entries in that contest are expected to roster him. Players above 25% are considered chalk; anyone under 10% is a leverage or contrarian play.

That single number reframes how you look at a slate. You stop asking only "who's good tonight" and start asking "who's good that everybody else already knows is good." Those are different questions. The gap between them is where tournaments are won.

Think of ownership as a map of the crowd. It doesn't tell you who'll score the most points. It tells you where everyone else is standing, so you can decide whether to stand with them or step somewhere quieter.

How Ownership Projections Are Calculated

Ownership projections are modeled from player salary, projected fantasy points, matchup quality, recent performance, and news or injury coverage. The base fantasy-point projection drives most of it: if a player projects well relative to salary, the field piles in, so ownership climbs.

No single input works alone. A cheap player in a pace-up game against a weak defense checks every box the public loves, and their ownership reflects that pile-on. Value drives the bus. Price a strong performer too low and the field can't resist.

News is the wild card. A late injury that opens 30-plus minutes for a $4,000 backup can send that player's ownership from 3% to 35% in an hour, because the site's salary won't catch up before lock.

Public perception matters too. A star coming off a bad game gets faded even when the matchup is still great, which quietly drops their ownership and hands you cheap leverage.

Every projection carries error bars. The models nail *relative* ownership, meaning they reliably rank who'll be most and least popular. The exact percentages wobble more than the rank order does, so treat a "22%" as a neighborhood, not a fixed address.

Why DraftKings and FanDuel Ownership Never Match

The same player gets rostered at different rates on DraftKings and FanDuel because the two sites use different scoring and roster rules. FanDuel's rigid position requirements tend to condense ownership onto a few clear plays, while DraftKings' flex spots spread it out. Multi-position eligibility is the biggest swing factor.

Here's a real example of how far apart they drift. On one two-game slate, a center eligible at both power forward and center on FanDuel projected as the highest-owned player on the board at nearly 70%, because his dual eligibility soaked up ownership from every other big. On DraftKings, where he was center-only, he fell to the sixth-most-owned player and a different star topped the slate above 70%.

Factor	DraftKings	FanDuel
Roster spots	8 (with flex positions)	9 (stricter position locks)
Position eligibility	Broader, more flex	Tighter, more fixed
Ownership shape	More spread out	More condensed on top plays
Scoring quirk	Double-double / triple-double bonuses	No bonus scoring

Those double-double and triple-double bonuses on DraftKings nudge ownership toward high-usage bigs and triple-double threats more than FanDuel does. Same slate, two different crowds. You need the ownership set for the site you're actually playing, not a blended average.

Never copy a FanDuel-shaped lineup straight onto DraftKings. The ownership map underneath it is different.

Using Ownership in Cash Games vs Tournaments

Ownership matters enormously in tournaments and barely at all in cash games. In cash you only need to beat about half the field, so you want the highest-floor lineup built straight from projections. Chalk is your friend there. In GPPs, where the money sits at the very top, duplication kills you.

The reason is payout structure. Cash games pay a large slice of the field with flat payouts, so a safe, popular, high-floor build clears the line just fine. If 40% of the field owns the same great chalk play and it hits, you all cash together and everyone's happy.

Tournaments flip that logic. When you and thousands of others post the same score, nobody separates. GPPs reward the lineup that's both high-upside *and* different from the pack. That's why ownership becomes the central input the moment you enter a large-field contest.

Contest type	What wins	Ownership's role
Cash (H2H, 50/50, double-up)	Highest floor	Minimal — chalk is fine
Small-field GPP	Floor plus a pivot or two	Moderate
Large-field GPP	Ceiling plus differentiation	Central to the build

Rule of thumb: never fire the same lineup into cash and a tournament. They want opposite builds. A common tournament framework keeps a core of three to five stable players (often chalk that's genuinely worth it) and surrounds them with mid-tier leverage plays and a contrarian piece or two.

Want the floor-first build for cash and the ceiling-first build for GPPs handled automatically? That's what the DailyFantasyPro optimizer is tuned for.

Leverage: The Real Reason Ownership Matters

Leverage is the gap between how often a player will win you the lineup and how often the field actually rosters them. A player with high upside and low ownership carries positive leverage; a heavily owned player with a shaky ceiling carries negative leverage. This is the concept ownership exists to serve.

Picture two players with similar projections. One sits at 30% ownership because he's famous and the narrative is loud. The other sits at 8% because he's in a neutral matchup with no headline. If both hit their ceiling, the 8% player gives you a far bigger edge, because only a sliver of the field shares him. That's leverage in one sentence.

Some tools formalize this. Simulation-based metrics compare a player's "optimal lineup percentage" — how often they appear in the best possible build across thousands of sims — against their projected ownership. When optimal-lineup rate sits well above ownership, the field is underrating that player and you've found your edge.

Here's the counterpoint worth respecting: some players argue you should auto-fade all heavy chalk. The data doesn't back that. A large majority of first-place millionaire-maker lineups over recent seasons included at least one player owned 25% or more. Chalk isn't the enemy. *Bad* chalk is. Deal with it case by case, not with a blanket rule.

The winning move isn't being different for its own sake. It's being different where being different actually pays.

Chalk, Chalk Traps, and When to Eat the Chalk

Chalk is any player projected for heavy ownership, usually 25% or higher. A chalk trap is a player whose ownership runs *ahead* of their real value — popular because of narrative, not because the projection supports it. Spotting the difference is a core NBA DFS skill.

The test is simple. Compare projected ownership to projected points at that position. If someone sits at 30% ownership but ranks 15th in projection among his position group, the field is overpaying on hype. That's a fade candidate in tournaments. Good chalk, by contrast, is popular *and* correctly projected, which makes it fine to roster even in GPPs.

The best low-owned plays hide behind a lack of story. A player in a bland matchup at a moderate salary with no injury headline can project nearly as well as a chalk play while carrying single-digit ownership. Those quiet spots are where tournament separation lives.

The Late-Swap Window Where Ownership Shifts

NBA ownership projections update all day and shift hard in the final 30 minutes before lock, because late injury news reshuffles the entire slate. A starter getting ruled out changes not just that player's ownership but every replacement, salary-saver, and pivot around them. This is the most valuable window in NBA DFS.

Most quality ownership feeds post an initial number by early afternoon Eastern and refresh every couple of hours, with a final update just before tip. That cadence exists for a reason: a lineup that's a winner 30 minutes before lock can be a dud 10 minutes later on a single injury report.

Late swap is the highest-value in-slate action you can take. When a point guard gets ruled out an hour before lock, his backup's minutes and usage spike while the site price stays frozen. Grab that underpriced beneficiary, spend the savings up on a stud, and you've turned news into edge. If you can't monitor news until lock, it's often smarter to skip tournaments that day entirely.

The Lineup Duplication Math People Get Wrong

Multiplying each player's ownership together estimates how often your exact lineup gets duplicated, and that math roughly holds in NBA because plays rarely correlate. It's a useful proxy. But a low duplication number does *not* prove your lineup is contrarian, and that's where a lot of players fool themselves.

Duplication and leverage are two different things. You can build a lineup with low expected duplication that's still full of players the field is correctly high on. Being un-duplicated isn't the same as being under the field on the pieces that matter.

Judge leverage player by player instead. Are you meaningfully under the crowd on your high-upside plays? Are you only paying up for chalk where it's truly earned? That player-level read is what actually moves the needle in large-field GPPs, not a single duplication percentage that looks reassuringly small.

Low duplication feels safe. Real leverage is a per-player decision, not one comforting number.

How Accurate Are These Projections, Really?

Modern ownership projections are highly reliable for relative popularity and looser on exact percentages. They correctly identify who'll be most and least owned, which is the part that actually drives strategy. The precise number attached to any single player carries more wobble than the rank order does.

That distinction changes how you should lean on them. Don't agonize over whether a player is 22% or 26% owned. Do trust the model when it tells you player A will be roughly three times more owned than player B. The ranking is the signal; the decimal is noise.

Accuracy also climbs through the day. Early-afternoon projections are a first draft built on expected news. As injury reports land, lineups get confirmed, and locks approach, the models sharpen. The read you get 20 minutes before tip is far tighter than the one from four hours earlier, which is exactly why the late window rewards attention.

Frequently Asked Questions

− What are NBA DFS ownership projections?

They're estimates of the percentage of contest lineups expected to roster each player. A 25% projection means about one in four entries will include that player.

+ How do I use ownership projections to win?

+ Are DraftKings and FanDuel ownership numbers the same?

+ What's a good ownership percentage for a GPP lineup?

+ Should I always fade high-ownership players?

+ When do ownership projections update?

+ What is a chalk trap?

DAILYFANTASYPRO

Free DFS lineup optimizers, ownership projections & tools for every sport.

OPTIMIZERS

NBA Lineup Optimizer

NFL DFS Optimizer

MLB DFS Optimizer

NHL DFS Optimizer

PGA DFS Optimizer

DFS Optimizer

PrizePicks Optimizer

BY SITE

DraftKings NBA Lineup Optimizer

FanDuel NBA Lineup Optimizer

FanDuel NFL Lineup Optimizer

FanDuel MLB Lineup Optimizer

FanDuel NHL Lineup Optimizer

UFC FanDuel Optimizer

Yahoo Fantasy Football Lineup Optimizer

PROJECTIONS & MORE

NBA DFS Ownership Projections

MMA DFS Ownership Projections

DFS Ownership Projections

PGA DFS Projections

NASCAR DFS Optimizer

Tennis DFS Optimizer

Soccer Lineup Optimizer

LEGAL & COMPANY

About Us

Contact Us

Privacy Policy

Terms of Service

Disclaimer

Cookie Policy

DMCA

© 2026 DailyFantasyPro. All rights reserved.

21+. Gambling problem? Call **1-800-GAMBLER**. Please play responsibly.